Seam finishing without an overlocker

A companion to Pattern Drafter. The diagrams show the fabric edge-on (cross-section), as if you cut through the seam and looked at it from the side.

Which finish goes where

SEAM	FINISH
Shirt	
Yoke to back, yoke to fronts	Burrito yoke
Sleeve to armhole	Flat-felled (sew the sleeve in flat, before closing the side seam)
Side + underarm (one continuous seam)	Flat-felled or French
Front facing edge	Turn-and-stitch
Collar, stand, cuffs	Enclosed by construction, nothing needed
Shirt hem, short sleeve hem	Narrow double-fold hem
Chest pocket	Fold top hem twice; press the sides under 1 cm
Trousers & shorts	
Side seams, inside leg	French (light fabric) or flat-felled (sturdy)
Crotch seam (front + back)	Reinforced curved seam
Pocket bags	French seam
Waistband / casing	Enclosed by the folded band
Fly facing (fitted)	Turn-and-stitch or bias binding
Leg hems	Double-fold hem

Before you start

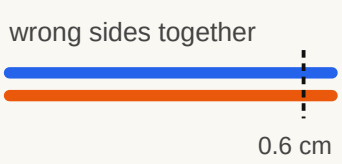
- Set **seam allowance to 1.5 cm** in the drafter. French and flat-felled seams need the extra width.
- Press every step. Pressing does half the work of a neat finish.
- Test each finish on scraps of your real fabric first.
- Linen and loose cotton weaves fray fast. Finish each seam right after sewing it.

Piece A · Piece B · Yoke · Bias binding · Stitching · ✂ Trim

French seam

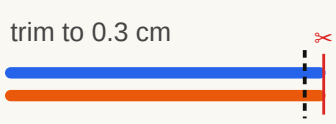
Light fabrics: shirt side and sleeve seams, trouser side and inside-leg seams, pocket bags. Needs 1.5 cm seam allowance.

1



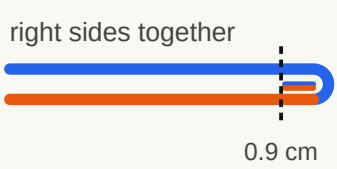
Put the pieces **wrong sides together** and stitch 0.6 cm from the edge.

2



Trim the allowance to 0.3 cm. Press the seam open, then press it to one side.

3



Fold along the seam so the **right sides** face each other, with the seam right on the fold. Press, then stitch 0.9 cm in.

4

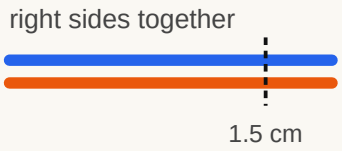


Open it out. The raw edges are sealed inside a neat tube. Press it to one side.

Flat-felled seam

The strongest, cleanest seam. Use it for shirt side and sleeve seams, shirt armholes, and sturdy trouser seams. Needs 1.5 cm seam allowance.

1



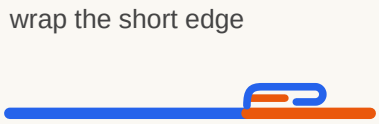
Right sides together, stitch 1.5 cm from the edge.

2



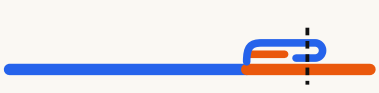
Trim **one** allowance (orange) down to 0.5 cm. Leave the other at full width.

3



Open the pieces flat. Press the wide allowance over the short one, then fold its raw edge under to wrap it.

4

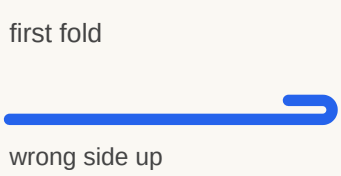


Press flat against the garment and topstitch close to the folded edge. It's neat on both sides.

Narrow double-fold hem

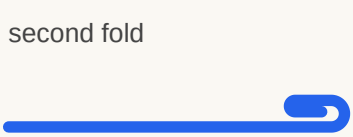
Shirt hems (including the curved shirttail), short-sleeve hems, shorts and trouser hems. The drafter's hem allowance already covers this.

1



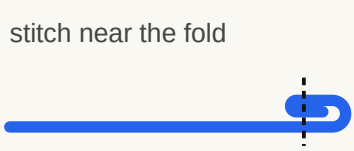
Press the raw edge up 0.5 cm toward the wrong side (1 cm on trousers and shorts).

2



Fold up again by the same amount, so the raw edge is hidden inside the fold. Press.

3

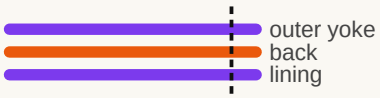


Stitch close to the inner fold. On curves, ease the fabric round slowly and don't stretch it.

Burrito yoke

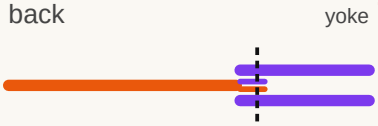
Hides every raw edge on the shirt yoke. You need two yoke pieces: the outer yoke and the lining.

1



Stack the outer yoke (right side down), the back (right side up), then the lining (right side up). Stitch through all three.

2



Flip both yokes up. The seam allowances end up hidden between them. Press, then topstitch.

3



Shoulders: lay the outer yoke on the fronts' shoulders, right sides together. Roll the back and fronts up tightly, wrap the lining around them, and stitch both shoulders through all three layers. Pull everything out through the neck.

Reinforced curved seam

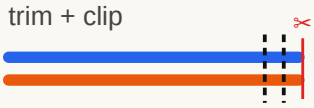
Trouser and shorts crotch seams, armholes if you're not flat-felling them, and any tight curve where enclosed seams would pucker.

1



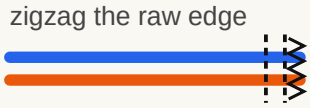
Stitch the seam at 1.5 cm, then stitch a second row 0.5 cm outside the first, in the allowance.

2



Trim the allowance to 0.6 cm. On the curve, clip into it every 2 cm, stopping short of the stitching.

3



Finish the edge with a zigzag stitch (or pinking shears), and press it to one side.

Turn-and-stitch (clean finish)

For any open seam in light to medium fabric. It's also how to finish the shirt's front facing edge.

1

press open



Sew the seam as normal and press it open.

2

fold under + stitch



Turn each raw edge under 0.3 cm and stitch along the fold. Stitch only through the allowance, not the garment.

Bias binding

For thicker fabric (denim, twill, heavy linen) where folding the edge would be too bulky. Cut 3 cm strips at 45° to the grain.

1

bias strip on top



Lay the bias strip on the allowance, right sides together, and stitch 0.6 cm in.

2

wrap + stitch



Wrap the strip around the raw edge to the back and stitch in the ditch from the front to catch it.